reportedly meet resistance from State Department diplomats who fear that Pakistani resentments built up in response to sovereignty violations and to the deaths of civilians are harmful to U.S. interests, outweighing potential gains.

A flurry of suspected Predator drone attacks on Pakistani territory in the latter months of 2008 suggests a shift in tactics in the effort to neutralize Al Qaeda and other Islamist militants in the border region. As of later November, at least 20 suspected Predator attacks had been made on Pakistani territory since July, compared with only three reported during all of 2007. Such strikes have killed more than 100 people, including numerous suspected foreign and indigenous fighters, but also women and children. The new Commander of the U.S. Central Command, Gen. David Petraeus, claims that such attacks in western Pakistan are "extremely important" and have killed three top extremist leaders in that region.[38]

Officially, Pakistan's Foreign Ministry calls Predator attacks "destabilizing" developments that are "helping the terrorists." Strident Pakistani government reaction has included summoning the U.S. Ambassador to lodge strong protest, and condemnation of missile attacks that Islamabad believes "undermine public support for the government's counterterrorism efforts" and should be "stopped immediately." During his first visit to Pakistan as Centcom chief in early November, Gen. Petraeus reportedly was met with a single overriding message from Pakistani interlocutors: cross-border U.S. military strikes in the FATA are counterproductive. Pakistan's defense minister warned Gen. Petraeus that the strikes were creating "bad blood" and contribute to anti-American outrage among ordinary Pakistanis. In November 2008, Pakistan's Army Chief, Gen. Ashfaq Pervez Kayani, called for a full halt to Predator strikes, and President Zardari has called on President-elect Obama to re-assess the Bush Administration policy of employing aerial attacks on Pakistani territory.[39]

Military Capacity Building in Pakistan

Some reports indicate that U.S. military assistance to Pakistan has failed to effectively bolster the paramilitary forces battling Islamist militants in western Pakistan. Such forces are said to be underfunded, poorly trained, and "overwhelmingly outgunned."[40] However, a July 2008 Pentagon-funded assessment found that Section 1206 "Global Train and Equip" funding — which supplements security assistance programs overseen by the State Department — is important for providing urgently needed military assistance to Pakistan, and that the counterinsurgency capabilities of Pakistani special operations forces are measurably improved by the training and equipment that come through such funding.[41]

Security-Related Equipment

Major government-to-government arms sales and grants to Pakistan since 2001 have included items useful for counterterrorism operations, along with a number of "big ticket" platforms more suited to conventional warfare. The United States has provided Pakistan with nearly $1.6 billion in Foreign Military Financing (FMF) since 2001, with a "base program" of $300 million per year beginning in FY2005. These funds are used to purchase U.S. military equipment. Defense supplies to Pakistan relevant to counterinsurgency missions have included more than 5,600 military radio sets; six C-130E transport aircraft; 20 AH-1F Cobra attack helicopters; 26 Bell 412 transport helicopters; night-vision equipment; and protective

Copyright © 2010. Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated. All rights reserved.

Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism in Pakistan's Border Region, Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central,